

## FREE CHECKLIST

# The Creator Business Setup Checklist

**Four steps and two bonuses. Under 90 minutes. Do them before the money shows up.**

If you're building a Creator business in the US, you need the same boring infrastructure any small business needs. Skip it and you're exposed: the IRS can freeze your revenue, an angry client can sue you for your house, and big-money partners pass on Creators who look unprofessional.

Fortunately, it's easy to set up.

I paid list price for all of this when I set mine up. Nobody negotiated for me, so I've negotiated for you and included the Creator Access Network discount wherever a partner exists: free subscriber rate first, paid member rate (\$24.50 a year for email subscribers, locked in for life) below.

**4**

STEPS

**2**

BONUS STEPS

**90**

MINUTES

**11**

PARTNER DISCOUNTS

## THE CHECKLIST

- 1 Register an LLC.** Bizee or LegalZoom, or your accountant or lawyer.
- 2 Open business bank and credit card accounts.** Mercury or Karat.
- 3 Do your bookkeeping, or hand it off.** QuickBooks, or Boring Stuff, ClearPath or Valim.
- 4 Connect everything and put your LLC on every contract.** DUPAY, Ratelle Law, Unbound Legal, Creators Guild of America.
- + Bonus: health coverage.** essentL.
- + Bonus: a website.** .store.

**Disclaimer:** I'm not a lawyer or an accountant, and this isn't legal or accounting advice. Talk to one; a few are below.

Some links in this checklist are affiliate links, which means CAN may earn a commission if you sign up, at no extra cost to you. Bizee, LegalZoom and QuickBooks are not partners; we make nothing if you use them.

## 1 Register an LLC.

Without an LLC (limited liability company), if you get sued over something business-related, they can come after your personal assets - house, stocks, bank account, everything.

If you do business through an LLC, they can only come after your business assets. It's not worth the risk - just do it.

### Two options:

- **Bizee**: cheap, easy, done. They're not a CAN partner and we make nothing if you use them. **LegalZoom** also works. Expect a few hundred dollars total, including state fees.
- A lawyer or accountant can also handle it, but for more. If you're planning to hire one anyway, then you might be able to roll the service into their cost. See Steps 3 and 4.

Already making over \$80K a year? Ask an accountant (Step 3) about an S Corp. There are tax benefits to using an S Corp instead of an LLC above a certain income level.

## 2 Open business bank and credit card accounts.

Even with an LLC, if you are collecting money in your personal bank account and spending on a personal credit card, then if someone sues you, they can argue that they should also be able to access the money in your personal bank account.

You need separate business bank and credit card accounts. Every dollar you earn through your business should land here; then pay yourself by transferring to your personal.

We have two great discounts from Creator banking partners - both of whom also offer credit cards:

### Mercury

BANKING

BUSINESS INFRASTRUCTURE

Free business banking. Massively popular among startups and small businesses, they're now heavily investing in Creators.

New Mercury customers only, at both rates.

#### FREE RATE

**Up to \$100 in deposit and spend bonuses**  
[mercury.com/partner/canetwork2](https://mercury.com/partner/canetwork2)

**MEMBER RATE Up to \$400 in deposit and spend bonuses**

### Karat

BANKING

BUSINESS INFRASTRUCTURE

Built for Creators, earn interest on business checking. Their Premium plan pays 1.75% interest on their Checking account - unheard of for business banking. That extra cash adds up as you grow your business. Banking and card are free; Premium is \$20/month.

Needs a US LLC (go back to Step 1). New Karat customers only.

#### MEMBER RATE

**3 months of Premium + a \$100 credit for holding a \$5K balance for 60 days, a \$160 value**

### 3 Do your bookkeeping...or don't, and hand it off.

You need clean books to file quarterly and year-end taxes.

**QuickBooks** is the DIY standard. They're not a partner (yet) but if you're going to do it yourself, just use them.

I pay an accountant because I hate thinking about it. CAN has 3 Creator-focused accounting partner discounts:

#### Boring Stuff **ACCOUNTING** **BUSINESS INFRASTRUCTURE**

Run by Creators, bespoke, best at \$100K+ a year.  
Retainers start around \$400/month.

New customers only; US or Canada based.

##### FREE RATE

**20% off the first 3 months, \$240+ saved**

Schedule a free consultation, select "CAN" on the intake form, and mention Creator Access Network

**MEMBER RATE 50% off your first 3 months, \$600+ saved**

#### ClearPath **ACCOUNTING** **BUSINESS INFRASTRUCTURE**

Bigger shop, fair prices, any size. They're CAN's own accountants. Tax-only from \$450; full service from \$500/month.

US only.

##### MEMBER RATE

**Free consult + 25% off tax services for a year, up to \$1,500 saved on full service**

#### Valim **ACCOUNTING** **BUSINESS INFRASTRUCTURE**

Ex-Big 4 CPAs with AI-powered processes enabling lower prices. Returns typically run \$800 to \$1,000.

New Valim clients only for the free rate.

##### FREE RATE

**20% off filings + a free tax planning consult, \$160 to \$200 saved per return**

Code **CAN20** at [valim.ai](https://valim.ai)

**MEMBER RATE 45% off, \$360 to \$450 saved per return**

## 4 Connect everything and put your LLC on every contract.

- Point every payout (Stripe, PayPal, YouTube, TikTok Shop) at the business account.
- Put every business expense on the business card.
- Address every contract to your LLC, not you; if a brand sends one with your name, ask them to change it.

These are real necessities. One personal card charge or contract under your name and not your LLC can put your personal finances at risk.

Speaking of contracts, if you need help chasing payments or want agreement templates you can safely use, CAN has some partners for that:

### DUPAY

BRAND DEALS

LEGAL

BUSINESS INFRASTRUCTURE

Contracts, invoicing, and collections when a brand won't pay. Tools is \$14/month; Tools + Protection is \$29/month.

#### FREE RATE

**30 days of Tools free, a \$14 value**  
[Start here](#)

**MEMBER RATE** 2 months of Tools + Protection free, a \$60 value, on annual plans

### Ratelle Law

LEGAL

BUSINESS INFRASTRUCTURE

RESOURCES

Attorney-drafted Creator contract templates. The Creator Legal Bundle is \$697.

US-focused templates; no attorney-client relationship.

#### MEMBER RATE

**30% off the bundle, \$209 saved**

### Unbound Legal

LEGAL

BUSINESS INFRASTRUCTURE

A top Creator Economy attorney for the big stuff. Packages run \$5,975 (15 hours) or \$10,975 (30 hours).

New clients only. Transactional work; litigation, trademark and corporate matters are excluded.

#### FREE RATE

**10% off a package, \$598 to \$1,098 saved**  
Email [chelsey@unbound.legal](mailto:chelsey@unbound.legal) and mention Creator Access Network Subscriber

**MEMBER RATE** 15% off, \$896 to \$1,646 saved

### Creators Guild of America

BRAND DEALS

RESOURCES

The guild membership that tells brands you're a pro (I'm on their Leadership team). Full membership is \$99/year.

US only, new members.

#### FREE RATE

**Join free as an Associate**  
[mosaic.creatorsguildofamerica.org/register](https://mosaic.creatorsguildofamerica.org/register)

**MEMBER RATE** First year of full membership free (\$99 value)

## + Health coverage.

No employer, no plan - in America, this is one of the biggest pain points for starting a Creator business.

Healthcare.gov works to protect you if you get hit by a bus, but prices have skyrocketed over the last year and most of those policies leave you many thousands out of pocket if you need care.

**essentL**

**BUSINESS INFRASTRUCTURE**

**INSURANCE**

Corporate-grade coverage built for Creators, backed by Cigna, and founded by two Creators who became their own first customers. The service fee is \$150/month.

The discounts are on essentL's fee; nobody can discount premiums, by law. US only.

### **FREE RATE**

**No admin fee, worth \$150**

Code **CREATORACCESSNETWORK** at  
[essentlcreator.com/avi](https://essentlcreator.com/avi)

**MEMBER RATE** 50% off the service fee for 6 months, worth \$450

## + Put the business in one place: a website.

Your bank, books and contracts now live in three different logins. A site with your business name on it is where they meet: your rates, your contact email, your links, and the address brands see on every invoice. The domain is the first step and the cheapest thing on this list.

**.store**

**WEBSITE & BIO LINK**

**BUSINESS INFRASTRUCTURE**

A domain built for anyone selling something. Standard, non-premium domains only; one per person.

### **FREE RATE**

**Your first year for \$0.99**

Code **CAN99** at [get.store/creators](https://get.store/creators)

**MEMBER RATE** Five years free, a \$200 value

### **That's the checklist.**

Want the member column on every line? It's \$24.50 a year for email subscribers, 50% off for life, to put thousands back in your pocket.

See you in your inbox!

**Avi**

[Join Creator Access Network](#)